

CORE RESOLUTION — 2D6 + STAT + SKILL

Roll (+mods)	Result
≤ 6	Miss — fail, or succeed at cost
7-9	Partial — yes-but, yes-and-cost
10+	Hit — clean success
12+	Exceptional — success with bonus

Wild outcomes — check the dice AS DICE, before modifiers:

- **Double 6s** → exceptional regardless of math; **player narrates** an unexpected positive detail
- **Double 1s** → mechanical result resolves normally with mods; **DM introduces** an unexpected complication or twist

DMs never roll. Players roll for uncertain outcomes; you narrate.

STATS (RANGE -2 TO +3; STARTING ARRAY +2/+1/+1/+1/0/0)

Stat	Covers
STR	lifting, brawling, physical labor
DEX	driving, fine motor, dodging, climbing
CON	endurance, illness, tolerance, sleep dep
INT	academics, languages, technical
WIS	willpower, intent, perception, intuition (modifies uncertain magic)
CHA	talk, presence, lying, reading rooms

SKILLS (MAX +2 FROM SKILLS, PLUS STAT)

Categories (+1 each): **Action** **Subterfuge** **Knowledge** **Insight** **Influence** **Tech** **Craft** **Medic**

Tags: open free-text specifics, +1 when fiction-relevant ("ICU nurse," "fluent Mandarin"). 3-5 at creation.

Cap: +2 from skills (one category + one tag, or two stacking tags), plus stat.

HARM (4-BOX TRACK)

#	State	Effect
1	Bruised	No penalty
2	Wounded	-1 to physical rolls
3	Serious	-1 to ALL rolls; needs care soon
4	Critical	Out. Dying or unconscious.

Healing is mostly fictional. Box 1 rest; Box 2 days; Box 3 medical; Box 4 significant.

STRESS (4-BOX TRACK)

#	State	Effect
1	Tense	No penalty
2	Strained	-1 to WIS rolls
3	Frayed	-2 WIS; thread debt accumulates faster
4	Broken	No casting; -1 to ALL rolls

Recovery: 1 box / night's sleep; 1 box / meaningful conversation-art-connection; never in-scene.

COMBAT (THEATER OF THE MIND; DM TURN-ORDERS NATURALLY)

Moves (anyone):

- **Attack** — Action vs target. Hit deals harm; Partial deals harm + you take some too.
- **Defend** — DEX/Action against incoming. Hit avoids; Partial reduces.
- **Maneuver** — change position / create advantage. Hit gives ally +1 to their next roll.
- **Aid** — help another's action directly. Hit gives +1.
- **Press** — force someone to reveal/give up. Influence-based.
- **Withdraw** — disengage. Hit clean; Partial at cost.

If tempo spikes: DM may call Insight; high rolls act first. Combat is rare and lethal; PCs are mostly civilians.

MAGIC — PLAUSIBILITY TIERS (DM ADJUDICATES)

Tier	Roll?	Outcome
Free	No	Succeeds; no debt
Cheap	No (WIS check for show)	Succeeds; minimal debt
Costly	2d6+WIS	10+ clean; 7-9 partial (higher cost than expected); ≤6 fails + debt anyway. +1 stress.
Hard	2d6+WIS with -1/-2 penalty	10+ partial only; 7-9 fail with major debt; ≤6 backlash. +2 stress.
Prohibited	—	Not allowed

Foci shift tier down by ONE within domain (Costly → Cheap, Hard → Costly; Prohibited stays). Foci can break/fade/transform on Hard casts.

Free/Cheap spam triggers a stress check after 3rd-4th in a scene. Roll 2d6+WIS; miss marks stress.

THREAD DEBT (NARRATIVE METER, NOT A NUMBER)

State	The world is doing
Quiet	Nothing notable
Noticed	Small "lucky timing" comments
Watched	Coincidences accumulate around caster; banks flag, friends ask
Pushing Back	Bad luck for the caster specifically; harder casts
Hunted	World actively obstructs; severe. Can't easily cast.

Narrate the state in fiction ("things have eased; the world's eye has drifted"), never by number. Eases with restraint.

ADVANCEMENT (SESSION END)

Each player may mark up to ONE:

- ☐ Resolved a hard moment in line with alignment
- ☐ Learned something true about The Quiet, world, or another character
- ☐ Took a meaningful risk for someone else
- ☐ Acted against own short-term interest because story demanded it
- ☐ Took a complication/scar that will matter later

Every 5 marks → 1 advancement (stat +1 cap +3; category mastery +1 → +2; new tag; new focus; NPC relationship; resource). Cap: 8 advancements per character.

ALIGNMENT

Standard 9-grid. Chosen at creation, **binding** — PCs act in accord even when short-term costly.

Drift tracker: DM privately notes actions that pulled toward a different quadrant. ~5 drift marks toward one destination → realignment conversation. Old vows feel wrong; old allies notice.

SILENT-PLAYER FIREWALL — NEVER SAY AT THE TABLE

magic · The Quiet · casting · cast · spell · premonition · psychic · chosen · destiny · awakening · the elect · sixth sense · thaumaturgy · sorcery

Instead say: *coincidence · luck · timing · weird · uncanny.*

Three lines memorized:

- "is this magic?" → "Could be. Could not be. What does your character do?"
- "what does it MEAN?" → "What do you think it means?" (then listen)
- "AI? Conspiracy?" → same as #1. Do NOT affirm; the theory must come from players.

DM-ONLY: MAGIC-DISCOVERY ARC (UNDERLEAF-SPECIFIC)

Phase 1 — Accidental (sessions 1-3): players have no cast on their sheets; DM silently grants Free/Cheap effects to strong intent, attributed to luck. Log in accidental-cast log.

Phase 2 — Realization (scripted, ~session 3-5): DM reveals the pattern. Player gains cast mechanics on their sheet.

Phase 3 — Trying-too-hard tax (~2-3 sessions after): intentional casts take -2 until PC has "one quiet moment of release" — an unforced spontaneous cast they didn't aim for. Drops tax to 0.

Each PC realizes on their own schedule. Release is the cue for the act break in Underleaf's three-act structure.

FOCI — QUICK DM REMINDER

Cognitive anchor, not a magic battery. Personal, idiosyncratic — a phrase, tool, breath count, song lyric, object.

Domain: emotion, systems/information, identity, motion, knowledge, body/care, memory/identity, speech/presence, posture/presence, etc.

Effect: shifts in-domain casts down one tier. Out-of-domain: no help.

Can break, fade, corrupt, or transform when spent on Hard casts.